

Guillermo Kardolus

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Backend and infrastructure engineer with 15 years of experience across Spotify, Coinbase (Bison Trails), Pivotal, Cloudera, and startups.

- Creator of **chatgpt-cli**, a multi-provider Go CLI for LLMs with **~1K GitHub stars**.
- Co-founded **Sidelight**, a staking accounting platform; reached **~\$100K ARR** with customers including Figment and stake.fish.
- **M.Sc. in Astrophysics** (University of Amsterdam); computational astrophysics, simulating stellar cluster evolution with CUDA on GPUs.

Experience

Software Engineer, Treeswift | Mar 2026 - Present *Python, Kubernetes, AWS, Terraform, Airflow*

- Built observability from the ground up: OpenTelemetry/Honeycomb distributed tracing, a Prometheus/Grafana monitoring stack, and PagerDuty on-call alerting.
- Led multi-tenant security and SOC2 readiness: tenant isolation, role-based access enforcement, audit logging, and Keycloak OAuth2 (M2M) replacing shared API keys.
- Built an internal pipeline-ops service with AI-assisted alert grouping (embeddings plus LLM judge), funnel analytics, semantic runbook search, and a cross-source audit trail; hardened the Airflow geospatial pipeline with failure classification, backoff retries, and OOM escalation onto tiered GPU node pools.
- Created a human-in-the-loop AI agent that runs the weekly on-call rotation (triage, similar-incident matching, runbook-driven fixes, approval-gated production actions) and a 45-tool Model Context Protocol (MCP) server giving every engineer's AI assistant access to pipeline state and runbooks.
- Drove cloud cost efficiency after a 48x AWS spend ramp: reproducible Karpenter vs Cluster Autoscaler benchmarks (latency, overshoot, cost per workload) and brought ClickOps production infrastructure under Terraform with zero-downtime imports.

Sabbatical | Apr 2025 - Mar 2026 Sailed for four months; earned a Class A CDL and a motorcycle license.

Senior Staff Engineer, Cloudera | Nov 2022 - Mar 2025 *Java, Go, Kubernetes, AWS, Azure*

- Designed and led the deployment of Apache Knox as a managed service on Kubernetes workload clusters, extending the Cloudera Control Plane.
- Developed a Kubernetes operator for Apache Knox enabling cross-cluster identity management via JWTs.
- Built an opt-in feature letting customers enforce stronger password policies across workload clusters.
- Created an LLM-powered GitHub bot that summarizes CI/CD build failures, cutting developer triage time.

Co-founder & CEO, Sidelight, Inc | Mar 2022 - Oct 2022 *Go, Kubernetes, GCP, PostgreSQL*

- Founded a crypto accounting platform for on-chain revenue; built full indexers for the top proof-of-stake networks, producing audit-ready staking revenue reports and an API with multi-fiat conversion.
- Reached ~\$100K ARR serving individual validators and leading staking providers including Figment and stake.fish.
- Recruited and led a team of 3 engineers; owned product, sales, and fundraising; secured multiple term sheets before winding down.

Senior Engineer, Spotify | Jan 2021 - Mar 2022 *Java, Go, C++, Kubernetes, GCP*

- Founding member of the Platform Consultancy squad, reducing technological fragmentation across Spotify.
- Consulted on scaling smart-speaker software, Spotify search, and the Heroic time series database.
- Led post-merger migrations and due diligence for acquisitions (Locker Room, Whooshkaa); authored a strategic report on migrating Spotify's data store, including cost analysis and industry benchmarking.

Software Engineer, Bison Trails (acquired by Coinbase) | Sep 2019 - Jan 2021 *Go, Kubernetes, AWS*

- Joined as one of the first ten team members and stayed through the January 2021 acquisition by Coinbase.
- Led a 5-engineer team indexing blockchains (Cosmos, Algorand, Livepeer) to power billing, tax form generation, and live validator monitoring; the groundwork for founding Sidelight.
- Built an API-token authentication service with a DB-less Kong ingress controller on Kubernetes.

Software Engineer, Pivotal (acquired by VMware) | Mar 2018 - Aug 2019 *Java, Go, Cloud Foundry*

- Technical lead for the Buildpacks team, contributing to the Cloud Native Buildpacks initiative (buildpacks.io).
- Added external encryption provider support and path-based ACLs to CredHub, used by two-thirds of Fortune 500 companies.
- Represented Pivotal at industry conferences, including SpringOne and Cloud Foundry Summit.

Software Engineer, BlackRock | Jan 2017 - Mar 2018 *Java, TypeScript, Cassandra*

- Built services on Aladdin, BlackRock's flagship investment platform: APIs over its Cassandra/ZooKeeper data layer and an AB-test framework for stress-testing services.
- Developed Java clients and servers for BlackRock's custom message broker, built to handle billions of messages per day.
- Designed a health dashboard visualizing service interconnections and statuses across Aladdin's test environment.

Software Engineer, Gap Inc. | Feb 2016 - Jan 2017 *Java, Spring, RabbitMQ*

- Optimized package allocation with sourcing algorithms driven by demand forecasts, pricing, and shipment factors, generating ~\$900K/month in profit for the logical inventory team.
- Partnered with the lead architect on a RabbitMQ-based messaging service, decoupling communication between microservices.

Lead Engineer, Bright River | Dec 2010 - Feb 2016 *Java, C#*

- Automated production workflows, supporting 300% company growth without additional staff.
- Increased organizational throughput by integrating custom backend software and automated file transfers.

Earlier Experience

- OGD (Netherlands), Software Engineer (2008 - 2009): contract development for organizations from government and hospitals to telecom giants and startups; designed and optimized databases, exposed through PHP and ASP.
- OGD (Netherlands), Systems Administrator (2005 - 2008): administered Windows and Linux file servers, backups, and mail servers; migrated a data center and security-tested networks and applications.
- Math and physics teacher before moving into software engineering.

Open Source & Projects

- **Personal cloud (kardol.us)**: own and operate a production-grade personal cloud on a self-hosted bare-metal Kubernetes cluster, replacing iCloud (Immich photo backup) and Dropbox (OpenCloud file sync); ~10 public apps behind Cloudflare tunnels with Keycloak SSO, MinIO object storage, Prometheus/Grafana/Alertmanager paging to PagerDuty, and nightly 3-2-1 backups with offsite replication; fully codified as infrastructure-as-code with a bare-metal recovery runbook.
- **chatgpt-cli**: multi-provider LLM command-line interface in Go (OpenAI, Anthropic, Gemini, xAI, and more), distributed via Homebrew.
- **Nemo Places (nemo.town)**: iOS app for saving favorite places and sharing them as per-context maps, live on the App Store; SwiftUI client with a link-based web companion, Android version in progress.
- **NYC open-data dashboards**: live crash map, crime map, and bikeshare analytics (Starlette, PostGIS, TimescaleDB) at *.kardol.us.

Education

M.Sc. Astrophysics, University of Amsterdam: computational astrophysics; researched stellar cluster evolution using CUDA/GPU N-body simulations.